⚖️ Civil Rights at the Turn of the Century: Reading

US History · Unit 5 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Jim Crow, Plessy v. Ferguson, Ida B. Wells, Washington vs. Du Bois, NAACP

Name: _____

Separate and Unequal

The 13th Amendment ended slavery in 1865. The 14th Amendment made formerly enslaved people citizens, and the 15th said men could not be denied the vote because of race. During Reconstruction, Black men voted in large numbers and more than a dozen served in Congress. But when federal troops left the South in 1877, white-led state governments began taking those rights away.

Southern states passed Jim Crow laws that segregated, or separated, Black and white Americans in schools, trains, hospitals, parks and cemeteries. They also blocked Black voting with poll taxes, literacy tests and “grandfather clauses” that excused white men whose grandfathers could vote. Threats and violence kept many from even trying. By 1900 almost no Black men could vote in some Southern states.

In 1892 Homer Plessy, a man of mixed race, sat in a whites-only train car in Louisiana to challenge the law. In Plessy v. Ferguson (1896), the Supreme Court ruled that segregation was legal as long as facilities were “separate but equal.” In reality Black schools and services received far less money. The decision stood until Brown v. Board of Education in 1954.

Journalist Ida B. Wells investigated lynching, the murder of Black Americans by mobs, often without any trial. Her reporting showed that many victims were targeted because they were successful or stood up for themselves, not because of crimes. After her Memphis newspaper office was destroyed, she continued her campaign from Chicago and across the world.

Black leaders disagreed about strategy. Booker T. Washington, founder of Tuskegee Institute, urged Black Americans to build skills and wealth first and to accept segregation for the time being. W.E.B. Du Bois, the first Black American to earn a Harvard PhD, insisted on demanding full civil and voting rights immediately. In 1909 Du Bois, Wells and others founded the NAACP, which fought discrimination in the courts and the press.

Check your reading

1. Name three ways Southern states blocked Black voters.

2. What did Plessy v. Ferguson decide, and why was it unfair?

3. Compare the strategies of Washington and Du Bois.